

Ratatosk's Muddled Message

The snowlit fjords of the north run deep and blue between white mountains and dark green pines, dotted with cosy longhouses whose windows glow warm amber against the snow. Above them arches the Great World Tree, and on clear nights the sky dances with the colours of the aurora. The fjords are full of gentle wonders: a chattering squirrel who carries messages along the tree, two thoughtful ravens, light spirits who dance in the dark, and frost giants who look fearsome but are mostly just cold and lonely. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a warm heart, dreams up ideas, and shares the fire. The grandest deeds are done by being brave and kind and full of ideas, and even a giant met with a friendly word often turns out lonelier than it is fierce.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.*

Before you begin

The Great World Tree holds the whole world together. Its roots reach far down into the deep dark earth, and its branches climb so high that an Eagle keeps a nest at the very top, above the snowlit fjords. All day long, a quick red squirrel named Ratatosk races up and down the trunk, carrying everyone's messages between the roots and the sky. He has never dropped one in his life. Until today.

Today Ratatosk got into such a hurry that he muddled every message up. Because of the mix-up, the great Eagle at the top of the tree now believes that a small friend down among the roots said something unkind about him. And the small friend, hearing the wrong words too, believes the Eagle said something unkind in return. Neither of them ever did. It was only a tangle of crossed messages. But the two old friends have turned their backs on each other, and the whole tree feels the chill of it.

Edda the Saga-Keeper called you to her side by the great fire of the Hearth Hall. "You have bright ideas and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more up there than any axe. Will you help poor Ratatosk sort his messages and set things right, so the two friends make up?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a ball of bright red yarn, a snack to coax a flustered squirrel, and a little lantern for the deep dark roots. "Remember," she said, "in these fjords we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."

★ *What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Imagination, Courage, or Heart?*

Stop 1 Catch the Squirrel

You stepped out beneath the Great World Tree, and there was Ratatosk, a streak of red fur zooming up the trunk, round a branch, and back down again, far too flustered to stop for anyone. "Sorry, sorry, no time, all muddled, can't stop!" he chattered as he whizzed past in a blur.

He was in such a panic that he could not help a single soul, least of all himself. Before anything could be mended, he needed to slow down, catch his breath, and rest.

★ *How might you help him feel calm? You carry a snack just for him. Could you sit very still and speak in a soft, slow voice? Could you watch the way he runs and wait patiently for the right moment to offer it?*

When you held the snack out gently and spoke low and kind, Ratatosk slowed, and stopped, and finally sat. He nibbled, his quick little breaths grew steady, and his racing heart settled at last. "Oh, thank you," he sighed. "It is so much easier to think when somebody is kind to you. Now, to the muddle."

Stop 2 Sort the Messages

Ratatosk opened his paws and out tumbled three little messages, all jumbled together in a heap. Three friends were waiting along the tree, he explained: the fierce-looking Eagle high at the very top, a kind old owl on a middle branch, and the small friend far down among the roots. Each message belonged to just one of them. But which message went to which friend? That was the muddle.

Down swooped the Two Ravens, Thought and Memory, to perch beside you. They fly over all the fjords and forget nothing, and they do love to drop a helpful hint for heroes who are truly trying.

★ *Can you remember who lives where on the tree? Read each message carefully and hunt for the clue inside it. One message speaks of the wind and the wide sky up high. One speaks of the cool deep dark down among the roots. One simply hoots a warm and friendly hello. So which friend does each message belong to?*

When you matched every message to its right friend, the great tangle melted clean away. "That's it! That's exactly it!" cheered Ratatosk, clapping his small paws together and spinning on the spot. Now you knew precisely what to carry, and to whom each kind, true message should go.

Stop 3 Climb and Deliver

One task remained, and it was the most important of all. The right message had to travel all the way up to the Eagle, and the right message all the way down to the small friend in the roots, so that each of them could hear the true words at last and understand.

The tree was very tall, and the way up was high and the way down was deep and dark. But you had your ball of bright red yarn.

★ *How will you climb safely without losing your way? Could you tie the red yarn at the bottom, like a safety line, and follow it up so you can always find the path back? Could you light your little lantern to see down among the deep dark roots?*

When you tied on the red yarn and climbed slowly and carefully, you came at last to the Eagle in his high nest. You read out the kind and honest message, the one that had been his all along. The Eagle's fierce frown softened into wonder. "Oh," he said quietly. "So my old friend was never unkind to me at all. It was only a muddle." Then you followed the yarn back down, down, down to the roots, your little lantern glowing, and you gave the small friend the true message too. The small friend's eyes went round and bright and happy.

Friends Again

High at the top of the Great World Tree, the Eagle spread his enormous wings and waved warmly down the trunk. Far below in the roots, the small friend waved right back up, and from top to bottom of the whole tree the two of them called out together, "Friends again!"

Ratatosk raced one joyful loop around the entire tree, his tail streaming behind him. "You sorted out my muddle and you mended my two friends," he said. "I will never, ever forget it.

Thank you, thank you, thank you!"

High above the snowlit fjords, where the aurora ripples teal and green and purple, Freya the Kind looked down and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your ideas, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the Snowlit Fjords.

Ratatosk's Muddled Message: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale of a mix-up mended with kindness, and good ideas and care win every time. Nobody is unkind on purpose, and nothing here is ever truly broken, only muddled and put right again.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Hearth Hall.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady, warm heart), or **Heart** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the red yarn, a small snack or token for the squirrel's snack, and anything at all for a lantern. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Heart together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these fjords, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Nori the Tomte pops up and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your warm heart again, and take back one energy star.
3	A following wind down the tree, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Two Ravens, Thought and Memory, glide past and nod kindly. All is well.
5	A lucky knot in the red yarn: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of hearth-warmth, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

There is no foe in this tale at all, only a muddle. The fierce-looking Eagle and the small friend in the roots are not enemies; they are old friends who have been hurt by crossed messages. The story is won not by beating anyone but by sorting the truth out and carrying the kind words to where they belong, so the two make up. Times spent puzzling out who said what, and carrying a kind message to a friend, sit happily alongside practice in memory, careful listening, and looking after others. Let the moment when the friends wave to each other land warmly; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

Ratatosk's Muddled Message: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: Catch the Squirrel (Easy)

The challenge. Ratatosk the Squirrel is zooming up and down the Great World Tree in a flustered panic, far too worked up to stop, listen, or help with anything. The players need to calm him and coax him to rest before the muddle can be sorted.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Observation moment. The kind move is to slow right down themselves: sit still, speak softly, watch the way Ratatosk runs, and at the right moment offer the **snack** Edda gave them. A patient, gentle child who matches the squirrel's path and waits for him will win his trust quickly.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have Ratatosk pause for breath right beside them so the snack is easy to offer, or let them spend an energy star to call out something calming that he hears. Any genuine kindness settles him. Once he is calm, he sits, nibbles, and thanks them, and the story moves on.

Stop 2: Sort the Messages (Normal)

The challenge. Ratatosk tips out three jumbled messages. Three friends are waiting on the tree, and each message belongs to exactly one of them. The players must remember who lives where and match each message to the friend it belongs to, using a clue tucked inside each one.

The three friends. Read them aloud so the children can picture the tree: **the Eagle** lives at the very top, high in the wind and the wide sky; **the Owl** sits on a middle branch, friendly and fond of a hello; and **the small friend** lives far down among the deep dark roots.

The three messages and their clues. Read each message and let the children work out who it belongs to:

- "The wind is wild up here today, but I love the wide sky." The clue is **the wind and the high sky**, so this message belongs to **the Eagle** at the top.
- "It is cool and quiet and cosy down in the deep dark, just as I like it." The clue is **the deep dark roots**, so this message belongs to **the small friend** in the roots.
- "Whoo, hello, lovely to see a friend on my branch!" The clue is the friendly **hoot** from a **branch**, so this message belongs to **the Owl** in the middle.

Intended solution. This is a Memory, Logic and Vocabulary moment. The good move is to read each message, find the clue word (high sky, deep roots, a hoot), and match it to the friend who fits. Matching all three sorts the muddle. The **Two Ravens** are on hand to confirm a good guess or nudge a stuck one.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have a Raven read one message aloud again, slowly, and ask "Now, who likes the wind up high?" Sorting even one message starts the others falling into place, and getting there with the Ravens' help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: Climb and Deliver (Normal)

The challenge. The right message must travel all the way up to the Eagle and the right message all the way down to the small friend, so each hears the true words and the two understand each other again. The way up is high and the way down is deep and dark.

Intended solution. This is a Spatial and Heart moment. The thoughtful, careful move is to tie the **red yarn** at the bottom as a safety line and follow it up and back, so the climbers can always find their way, and to light the **little lantern** for the deep dark roots. Then comes the kind part: read each friend their true message warmly, so the Eagle and the small friend each realise the unkind words were never real, only a muddle.

Fallback. If the children feel the climb is too high, let Ratatosk scamper alongside to show the safest branches, or let them spend an energy star to climb hand in hand. If they are unsure what to say, the kind message can be as simple as "Your friend was never cross with you; it was all a mix-up." The moment the true words are spoken, the friend's frown turns to delight.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser, because there was never a foe, only a tangle of messages. When the right words reach the right friends, the Eagle high in the tree and the small friend down in the roots wave warmly to each other and call out, "Friends again!" Ratatosk thanks the heroes with a happy loop around the tree, and **Freya the Kind** smiles down from above the snowlit fjords. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.